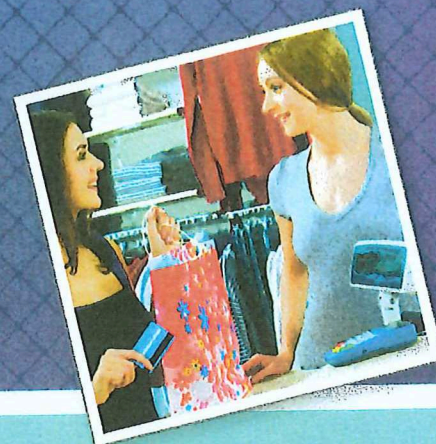


15

APPLYING FOR A JOB: YOUR CV



BEFORE YOU START

Most employers want to see your CV (= curriculum vitae, known as a *résumé* in American English). Your CV is a summary of your education, skills and work experience, plus your contact details. It may open with a personal statement. Your CV should give employers the information they need to decide if you are right for a job.

Writing clearly

- 1 Read Agata's CV opposite. Complete it with the headings that are listed in the box below, paying attention to the order in which they appear on Agata's CV.

Education/Qualifications

Work Experience

Skills

Personal statement

Referees

- 2 In her CV, Agata uses different adjectives to describe her personal qualities and skills. Find and circle the adjectives.

Example: I am an experienced waitress.

Choosing adjectives for your CV

- Adjectives such as *skilled*, *professional* and *hardworking* tell an employer about your personal qualities. They describe what kind of person you *are*, rather than what you can *do*.
- It's important to choose adjectives that describe you accurately. If you say you are reliable, make sure you can give examples to prove it.
- Try to use a variety of adjectives in your CV. Simply repeating that you are a 'good' communicator and 'good at' customer service doesn't tell an employer very much.

Writing a personal statement for your CV

A personal statement is a paragraph that summarizes your skills and personal qualities. Not all CVs include them, but they can be a useful way to catch an employer's attention. They also add a personal touch to a document that can otherwise seem like a rather dull list.

A personal statement should be short (less than 100 words). It should be written in complete sentences, not bullet points or a list. You should use adjectives that describe the personal qualities that make you suitable for the job you are applying for.

Agata Nowak

Flat 2a, 12 Middlemarch Road,
 London SW17 4ES
 0776588347
 agy.nowak@dmail.com

1

Currently studying English in London, I am looking for part-time work in a challenging customer service role. An experienced waitress and shop assistant, I am versatile, reliable and polite. I enjoy busy and demanding jobs and look forward to learning more new skills.

2

2011 Certificate of English (Upper Intermediate)
 Princes College, Fulham

2007–2010 Maturity Certificate,
 Wroclaw Technical College

3

2009–2010 Counter Assistant,
 Mode Fashions, Wroclaw

I kept this popular shop tidy, attractive and well stocked at all times, served customers and worked on the till.

2007–2009 Waitress,
 Condor Café, Wroclaw

I served customers, cleaned tables and also helped in the kitchen of this busy restaurant.

4

- Confident English speaker (Upper Intermediate level).
- Fluent in Polish and German. An able communicator and enthusiastic team member.
- Excellent customer service skills.
- Competent in all Microsoft Office® software.
- Attained Level 2 Award in Food Hygiene & Safety for Catering (2011).

5

Mrs Katherine Chapman,
 Senior Teacher of English,
 Princes College, Fulham
 k.chapman@princesfulham.co.uk
 0208 443 6767

Mr Aleksandr Zawadzki,
 Manager, Mode Fashions,
 Wroclaw
 a.zawadzki@mode.pl
 +48 67 665 5892

Looking more closely

Read each example of a personal quality 1–5, then write another sentence to show what it means.

- 1 I am very reliable. *I always come to work on time.*
- 2 I am an experienced office worker.
- 3 I am hardworking.
- 4 I am professional.
- 5 I am skilled with computers.

Language note

When we write about work experience, we use the simple present tense or present continuous to talk about the job we are doing now. To save space, we write short sentences and sometimes miss out the subject of the sentence (I) and start with the verb.

Examples *(I) provide support to a team of nurses.*
Providing support to a team of nurses.

When we talk about jobs we did in the past, we use the simple past tense.

Examples *(I) served customers; (I) worked on the till; (I) cleaned tables.*

Language focus

- 1 Complete the descriptions 2–10 with verbs from the box. Change each verb to the simple past tense.

- 1 *Helped* school children with their reading.
- 2 questions from museum visitors.
- 3 reports and filing in the office.
- 4 a tractor and helped to feed farm animals.
- 5 customers in the restaurant.
- 6 sandwiches and desserts in the kitchen.
- 7 boxes and crates in the delivery department.
- 8 letters and parcels to local residents.
- 9 French and Italian to adults at evening classes.
- 10 documents from Hungarian to Spanish.

drive	help
do	serve
answer	write
translate	deliver
teach	prepare
pack	

- 2 Write a sentence describing the main responsibilities of each job 2–5 below. Use the present continuous tense.

1 Language teacher

Teaching classes and helping students with their language skills.

2 Waiter/Waitress

3 Book shop assistant

4 Cleaner

5 Restaurant manager

Get writing

- 1 Write your personal statement.
- 2 Now write the rest of your CV. Before you start, review all the advice in this unit, and look at Agata's CV again.

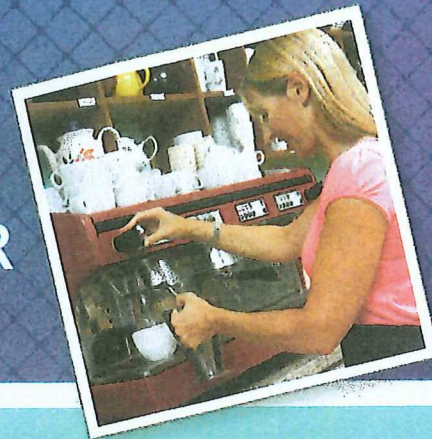
USEFUL TIPS

- Be concise. Try to keep your CV short. However, if you are applying for a graduate job that requires a lot of experience, a longer CV may be acceptable.
- If you aren't sure what to include, ask. Read the job advertisement carefully. If that doesn't help, call the company and ask what they need to know. Big companies will have an HR (= human resources) department who can advise you.
- Use a spellcheck and re-read your CV several times before you send it. Employers often receive lots of CVs, so even a small mistake can count against you! If you don't have much work experience, consider including an 'Achievements' section, to show employers some of the important things you have done, for example:

Achievements

- Won national synchronized swimming contest three years in a row.
- Was promoted twice in my first year at High Street Bank.
- Completed the London Marathon, raising £3,000 for charity.

16 APPLYING FOR A JOB: YOUR COVERING LETTER



BEFORE YOU START

When you apply for a job you will normally send a covering letter with your CV. This is true whether you apply by post or by email. Your covering letter helps you to 'advertise' yourself and adds a personal touch to your application. A good covering letter will emphasize your most relevant skills in a way that your CV can't, and can persuade an employer that you are the right person for the job.

Understanding

- 1 Read the covering letter for a bar job that is shown opposite.**
 - What's in the subject line?
 - What is the function of the first line of the covering letter?
 - What does the first full paragraph then tell you about Madeleine?
 - What does Madeleine explain in her second paragraph?
 - How does Madeleine complete her covering letter?
- 2 Read Madeleine's covering letter again. Answer questions 1–4:**
 - 1 How did Madeleine hear about the job?
 - 2 What relevant experience does she mention?
 - 3 What might make Madeleine's letter stand out?
 - 4 Why does she think she is suitable for this role?

Writing appropriately

Which of the following would you include in a covering letter?

- Details of your school exam grades.
- A summary of your work experience.
- Your address.
- Your age.
- Why you want to leave your current job.
- Your present salary.

To...	dragonflies@cmail.com
Cc...	
Send	
Subject:	Full-time Bar Manager, Dragonflies Bar-Restaurant: Madeleine Michel

Dear Mr Gregory,

I am applying for the post of Full-time Bar Manager, as advertised in *The List* on Friday 1 March.

I am an experienced and versatile bar person, having worked in the industry for the past five years in a number of increasingly responsible roles. I am currently Assistant Bar Manager at the bar-restaurant Olive, where I not only helped hire, train and manage a team of enthusiastic young bar people, but created a popular cocktails list to complement our food menu. As a direct result, Olive recently won an award for its cocktail innovation. I have really enjoyed working in such a demanding and rewarding role; nevertheless I feel that I am more than ready to meet the challenge of running a city-centre bar single-handed.

Because of my experience and drive, and since I have worked in a wide range of bar-restaurants, I believe that I have what it takes to successfully manage Dragonflies Bar-Restaurant and develop it into an even more profitable business. I would welcome the opportunity to prove my knowledge and ability in such an exciting new environment. Therefore, I would be very grateful if you would consider my application. My CV is attached, in pdf format as requested.

I very much look forward to hearing from you,

Madeleine Michel

USEFUL TIPS

- A good covering letter will give a summary of your most relevant experience and achievements, without repeating all the detail of your CV. Remember that this is a letter, not an essay.
- Your covering letter must show how you are different from other applicants, and it must show why you want this particular job (and not just any job). Before you write your covering letter, do some research on the company you are applying to. Use your research to explain why you want to work there.
- It is usually a good idea to briefly mention why you are applying for a new job, but be careful. If you hate your present job, that is not a good thing to put in a covering letter. Employers want to know that you really want to work for them, not that you are trying to get away from somewhere else!

Language focus

- 1 Read the covering letter on page 65 again. Identify the words and phrases that connect one idea to another.

In a covering letter, we can use connecting words to show how our experience and skills relate to the job description.

Example *Because of my experience with ... I feel I'd make an excellent ...*

Other connecting words and phrases should show how our actions caused a successful result, making us a more appealing applicant:

Example *I revised our workflow processes, and as a result, productivity improved.*

- 2 Complete the sentences 1–5 with suitable connecting words from the box. More than one answer may be correct.

- 1 of my revisions to the menu, more customers came to the café.
- 2 did profitability improve, but my team were happier too.
- 3 that I have worked in the industry for over 5 years, I believe I have the necessary experience for this role.
- 4 I am applying to your company I believe in your values and admire your history.
- 5 I hired and trained two new staff., efficiency was increased by 50%.

consequently
because
due to the fact
serve
as a result
not only

Some common mistakes with covering letters

- Writing too much information: recruiters are often too busy to read long covering letters.
- Getting the name of the company, the manager or the job wrong: this is usually an excuse for employers to dismiss your application completely! Check and double-check.
- Spelling and grammatical errors: with spell-checking software, there is no excuse for this.
- Not saying why you want to work for that company: your covering letter needs to be targeted, not general.
- Cutting and pasting text from another application: this tells employers you are careless and not very interested in them.
- Not following the instructions in the advertisement: some companies ask applicants for a hand-written covering letter. If you write your letter by hand, make sure that it is very clear and easy to read. If the employer does not specify a hand-written letter, you may type it, but choose your font carefully (usually a fairly traditional style) and lay your letter out clearly.

Language note

Taking the initiative in applying for a job can be hard. It is difficult to know what to write to someone you have never met, about a job you may know very little about. Here are some helpful phrases for sounding confident in your covering letter.

To start:

*I am applying for the position of ..., which I saw advertised ... on ...
write in response to your job advertisement, as seen on ...*

To show how you meet the job requirements:

I have 3 years' experience as leader of a productive and successful call centre team.

I'm a capable, professional waitress, with wide-ranging experience of the catering industry including: ...

In my time at Company X, I increased profitability/reduced waiting times/ helped my company win an award ...

To say why you want a new job:

*After three years in my present job, I feel it is time to take on a new challenge.
Having finished my degree I am seeking a role that utilizes all of my skills.*

To close:

I would welcome the opportunity to discuss my suitability for this role in person.

I attach my CV in support of my application.

I look forward to hearing from you.

Get writing

Look for a job advertisement online or in a local paper. Find one that matches your skills and experience. Write a covering letter.

- Make it clear which job you are applying for.
- Check you have the contact details and job title correct.
- Summarize the relevant experience from your CV, but don't repeat all the detail.
- Say why you are applying for this job.
- Include some information that makes you stand out from other applicants.